given the title Maharaja. So widely and relentlessly did this formidable warrior travel to maintain order in the empire, from his home state in the desert to the high plateaus of Kabul and the forests of the Deccan, that it was said of him that ‘his saddle is his throne’. Another favourite of Akbar’s was Rai Singh’s brother, Kuar Prithviraj, popularly called Peethal, who was not only an exceptional warrior, but also a flamboyant poet and scholar, and would become a beloved and much appreciated member of the Mughal court. Peethal and the Padshah also became brothers-in-law when two daughters of the Raja of Jaisalmer, Champa Dey and Nathi Bai, married Peethal and Akbar respectively.

The incorporation of Bikaner and other Rajasthani regions brought rich trade routes and market centres into the Mughal Empire. A dizzying variety of goods were traded through caravans including ‘ivory, copper, dates, gum-arabic, borax, coconuts, silk, chintzes, muslin, shawls, sandalwood, camphor, dyes, drugs, spices, dried fruits, cumin seeds, dyed blankets, potash and salt’. Various transit taxes brought further riches into the empire’s coffers. In western Rajasthan, merchandise was placed under the protection of Charan bards who, in courageous imitation of the Rajputs whose bravery they extolled, were willing to defend these goods to the death in an act of suicide known as performing chandi. Indeed, the killing of a Charan who was protecting a caravan was considered as heinous as killing a Brahmin, ‘with all its post-life connotations of hell-fire and damnation’.

All these many changes that Akbar was bringing about were all meticulously recorded, the Padshah’s every pronouncement noted down. For this, Akbar would have a group of scribes, fourteen in total, who were in attendance upon the Padshah, two at a time. The scribes had a kalam-daan (pen box), containing reed pens, an inkwell, sand, etc. At court, they sat cross-legged on the ground close to the Padshah with their reed pens at the ready, to note down his every order.

> All applications and documents presented to the court, and all orders and enquiries from the ruler, were written down by the particular scribe responsible, to be read out in court the following day. No imperial order could be executed without confirmation from the scribe that the case had been presented to the ruler as recorded. This confirmation then had to be recorded in the farman…the correct